



U.S. Citizenship
and Immigration
Services

Control Number: COW2026000731

March 24, 2026

Michael Wriston
Via Digital Request

Dear Michael Wriston:

We received your request for information on February 7, 2026. Your request asked for:

"Pursuant to the Freedom of Information Act, 5 U.S.C. § 552, I request records sufficient to describe the nature, purpose, and operational use of the tool known as "VOWS" (Vetting of Wedding-Based Schemes), reportedly developed or supported by Palantir Technologies and used by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. This request is limited to records created or updated from January 1, 2025 to the present. Specifically, I request the following categories of records: 1. System descriptions, concept of operations documents, or equivalent materials that describe what VOWS is and how it is used by USCIS personnel. 2. Privacy Impact Assessments, System of Records Notices, or internal privacy or civil liberties assessments specific to VOWS. 3. Policies, guidance, or standard operating procedures governing reliance on VOWS outputs in adjudicative or investigative decision-making. This request does not seek source code, algorithms, model weights, or sensitive technical vulnerabilities. If any portion of the requested records is exempt from disclosure, please release all reasonably segregable non-exempt material. Fee Waiver: I request a waiver of all search, review, and duplication fees pursuant to 5 U.S.C. § 552(a)(4)(A)(iii). Disclosure of the requested information is in the public interest because it is likely to contribute significantly to public understanding of the operations and activities of the government and is not primarily in my commercial interest. The requested records concern the use of an automated or data-driven vetting tool in immigration adjudications, an area implicating due process, privacy, and civil liberties. There is substantial public interest in understanding how such tools are deployed, what safeguards govern their use, and the extent to which their outputs may influence government decision-making. Disclosure of these records will contribute meaningfully to public understanding by shedding light on USCIS's policies and practices regarding algorithmic or analytic systems used in marriage-based immigration contexts—information that is not otherwise publicly available in sufficient detail. I intend to analyze and disseminate any information received through reporting and public-interest research, making the results available to a broad audience. I have no commercial interest in the requested information. If you determine that a fee waiver is not appropriate, please notify me in advance if estimated fees are expected to exceed \$25. If you have any questions regarding this request or believe it can be further narrowed to expedite processing, please contact me."

We may need to contact you at a later date to discuss the scope of your request.

Your request is being handled under the provisions of the Freedom of Information Act (5 U.S.C. § 552). It has been assigned the following control number: COW2026000731. Please cite this number in all future correspondence about your request.

We respond to requests on a first-in, first-out basis and on a multi-track system. Your request has been placed in the complex track (Track 2).

Based on the information you provided, we have determined that expedited processing of your request is

not warranted. The Department of Homeland Security Freedom of Information Act regulation at 6 C.F.R. § 5.5(e)(1) requires that you demonstrate that your request warrants expedited treatment because it involves:

- (i) Circumstances in which the lack of expedited processing could reasonably be expected to pose an imminent threat to the life or physical safety of an individual;
- (ii) An urgency to inform the public about an actual or alleged federal government activity, if made by a person who is primarily engaged in disseminating information;
- (iii) The loss of substantial due process rights; or
- (iv) A matter of widespread and exceptional media interest in which there exist possible questions about the government's integrity which affect public confidence.

Additionally, 6 C.F.R. § 5.5(e)(3) requires that a requester who seeks expedited processing must submit a statement, certified to be true and correct, explaining in detail the basis for making the request for expedited processing. Furthermore, requests for expedited processing that are based on paragraph (e)(1)(iv) of this section must be submitted to the Senior Director of FOIA Operations, the Privacy Office, U.S. Department of Homeland Security, 245 Murray Lane SW STOP-0655, Washington, D.C. 20598-0655. If you can demonstrate any further showing as to the nature and degree of (i), (ii), or (iii) of the above categories, please submit this additional information to this office for reconsideration.

You have the right to file an administrative appeal within 90 days of the date of this letter. By filing an appeal, you preserve your rights under FOIA and give the agency a chance to review and reconsider your request and the agency's decision. You may file an administrative FOIA appeal by mail to USCIS FOIA/PA Appeals Office, 150 Space Center Loop, Suite 500, Lee's Summit, MO 64064-2139. Both the letter and the envelope should be clearly marked "Freedom of Information Act Appeal."

If you would like to discuss our response before filing an appeal to attempt to resolve your dispute without going through the appeals process, you may contact our USCIS FOIA Public Liaison by email at FOIAPAQuestions@uscis.dhs.gov.

A USCIS FOIA Public Liaison is an agency official to whom FOIA requesters can raise concerns about the service the requester has received from the agency's FOIA Office. USCIS FOIA Public Liaisons are responsible for assisting in reducing delays, increasing transparency, and understanding of the status of requests, and assisting in the resolution of disputes.

If you are unable to resolve your FOIA dispute through our USCIS FOIA Public Liaison, you may contact the Office of Government Information Services (OGIS) at the National Archives and Records Administration to inquire about the FOIA mediation services they offer. The contact information for OGIS is Office of Government Information Services, National Archives and Records Administration, 8601 Adelphi Road-OGIS, College Park, Maryland 20740-6001; email ogis@nara.gov; telephone 202-741-5770; toll free 877-684-6448; or facsimile 202-741-5769.

Your request for a fee waiver has been granted.

Consistent with 6 C.F.R. § 5.5(a) of the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) FOIA regulations, USCIS processes FOIA requests according to their order of receipt. Although USCIS' goal is to respond within 20 business days of receipt of your request, FOIA does permit a 10 business day extension of this time period in certain circumstances. Due to the increasing number of FOIA requests received by this office, we may encounter some delay in processing your request. Additionally, due to the scope and nature of your request, USCIS will need to locate, compile, and review responsive records from multiple offices, both at headquarters and in the field. USCIS may also need to consult with another agency or other component of the Department of Homeland Security that have a substantial interest in the

responsive information. Due to these unusual circumstances, USCIS will invoke a 10 business day extension for your request pursuant to 5 U.S.C. § 552(a)(6)(B). Please contact our office if you would like to limit the scope of your request or to agree on a different timetable for the processing of your request. We will make every effort to comply with your request in a timely manner.

The National Records Center (NRC) has the responsibility to ensure that personally identifiable information (PII) pertaining to U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) clients is protected. In our efforts to safeguard this information, we may request that additional information be provided to facilitate and correctly identify records responsive to your request. Though submission of this information is voluntary, without this information, your request may be delayed while additional steps are taken to ensure the correct responsive records are located and processed. Further, if we are unable to positively identify the subject of the record we may be unable to provide records responsive to your FOIA request.

How to Check the Status of Your Request

You may check the status of your FOIA request online at first.uscis.gov/#/check-status. If you have any questions concerning your pending FOIA/PA request, or to check the status of a pending application or petition, please call the USCIS Contact Center at 800-375-5283 (TTY 800-767-1833).

How to submit Questions or Changes

Questions concerning this FOIA/PA request may be emailed to FOIAPAQuestions@uscis.dhs.gov. All FOIA/PA related requests, including address changes must be submitted in writing, and signed by the requester. Please include the control number listed above on all correspondence. For more information regarding the USCIS FOIA Program, please visit the USCIS website at www.uscis.gov/FOIA.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads "Jarrod T. Panter". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Jarrod" being more prominent than the last name "Panter".

Jarrod T Panter

Acting Chief FOIA Officer

Freedom of Information Act & Privacy Act Unit